

Hindu temples

The earliest Hindu temples were constructed in the fourth to fifth centuries CE. Over the ensuing years, they were built in many variations, adapted to the worship of different deities and to regional beliefs. Despite their differences, all were open, symmetrical constructions, built on square grids. Each temple comprises an inner sanctum and the *garbhagriha* or 'womb-chamber', housing the image of the primary idol or deity. Above the *garbhagriha* is the tower-like *shikhara*, or *vimana*, and an ambulatory for *parikrama* (circumambulation). Another staple is a congregation hall, and sometimes an antechamber and porch. The earliest examples were made of clay with roofs thatched with straw or leaves; later, brick and stone were used.

The Hindu culture encouraged creative independence, but architects and builders nonetheless had to adhere to certain 'rules', including precise and harmonious geometry throughout, tall towers, and ornate sculptures of gods, worshippers, erotic scenes, animals, and floral and geometric patterns.



Hindu temple at Khajuraho, Madhya Pradesh, c. 1000 CE